

Prince of Purpose

From repudiating the tradition of patronage to redefining the idea of social justice, the most favoured son of hereditary politics has brought the biggest cultural shift in India's oldest party

| By Priya Sahgal |

It was on a crisp December afternoon that a group of students from the Aligarh Muslim University asked Rahul Gandhi a question that would have left many of his seniors grappling for excuses. "Why has India not had a Muslim Prime Minister?" they asked. Unfazed, Rahul asked a counter question. "Can you name five young Muslim leaders?" After a brief silence, a student suggested Salman Khursheed, the minister for minority affairs. "I know he looks about 45, but he is much older than that," grinned Rahul and asked for another name. The next on the list was Omar Abdullah, the undoubtedly young chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir. "Yes, he is young," conceded Rahul. "But he is like me and he, too, has come up from the dynasty. Anyone else?" There was complete silence at the Kennedy Hall of the university. "This is what I mean. We need more people like you to join politics," said the young MP who aspires to be India's own JFK. He also gently reminded the predominantly Muslim gathering of the fact that India already had a minority leader as a prime minister, so others should feel encouraged and not discriminated against.

